



International Youth Day ‘25 at the UN:

The GVMUN team recently got a chance to attend International Youth Day (IYD) - hosted by AFS, UNITAR, and the Mission of Malta to the UN - at the UN Secretariat Building in NYC. We participated in sessions centered on how young people are advancing multilateral cooperation through technology and partnerships.

AFS’ celebration focused on the theme “Youth Advancing Multilateral Cooperation Through Technology and Partnerships,” bringing together youth leaders, UN officials, diplomats, and civil society to discuss how digital tools can strengthen cooperation and civic participation. Speakers included Felipe Paullier (Assistant Secretary-General for Youth Development, UN Youth Office), Samim Hamidy (UNITAR), Daniel Obst (AFS), Dana al Anzy (Education Above All), Ilan Enverga (International School for Better Beginnings), Shah Choudhury (Footsteps Bangladesh), and others (for a full list, please refer to the event information from AFS website).

The gathering complemented the official UN International Youth Day 2025 observance on 12 August, led by UN DESA, which highlights “Local Youth Actions for the SDGs and Beyond,” with the global commemoration taking place in Nairobi in collaboration with UN-Habitat. Together, the observances emphasize youth as partners in policy and implementation at every level.

From the dais, speakers repeatedly stressed that youth leadership is already reshaping institutions. “Young people aren’t just future leaders. You are already leading,” said Samim Hamidy, Project Officer at UNITAR. “Technology can connect us, but only people can unite us,” added Daniel Obst, President and CEO of AFS, underscoring that digital tools must serve human relationships and inclusive decision-making.

Other interventions reinforced the urgency of equipping youth with the right tools. “Using technology is a lifeline, to organize, to educate, to advocate,” said Dana al Anzy of Education Above All. Ilan Enverga observed that “AI and technology completely changes what education means,” while Shah Choudhury of Footsteps Bangladesh noted, “Today, technology has given us the power... to make the impossible, possible.” In video remarks, Felipe Paullier praised youth as essential partners in multilateralism, echoing the day’s through-line that young people shape outcomes, not just agendas.

GVMUN at the UN

GVMUN delegates attended sessions inside the UN complex, including time in the ECOSOC Chamber, engaging with peers and experts on policy, education, and technology. The team highlighted their own efforts to translate debate into action through research, outreach, and youth-led initiatives.

Pivot to Policy

This UN engagement comes as GVMUN pivots toward policy impact. Building on its conferences and training programs, GVMUN is expanding workstreams that produce youth policy briefs, white papers, and structured recommendations for decision-makers, and will continue to bring our team into UN-adjacent convenings to inform that work. Upcoming priorities include contributions aligned with the 2025 themes on localized SDG action, as well as programming that helps students responsibly apply AI and digital tools to civic engagement.

“International Youth Day reminded us that policy is most powerful when those it affects help shape it,” said Secretary-General Kush Dave. “We’re doubling down on programs that turn youth perspectives into concrete proposals and partnerships,” added Secretary-General Ayushmaan Mukherjee.

About International Youth Day 2025

AFS/UNITAR’s New York event on 8 August amplified the role of youth, technology, and cross-sector collaboration in multilateral work and was recorded by UN Web TV. It was part of a larger 3-day event for the International Youth Assembly

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